



are very proud of their country, believing it to be highly **cultured**, and in possession of the best food and wine. They value a chic personal **appearance**, and the pleasant presentation of even the most basic foods and commodities is

taken for granted. Intellectual and cultural life are important too, and there is a strong movement to protect French language and culture from being **overwhelmed** by foreign influences.

BASTILLE DAY

On July 14, 1789, the French people stormed the Bastille Prison, beginning the revolution that freed them from the monarchy and made the country a republic. The day is celebrated every year as a national holiday.



ENDURANCE TEST

The *Tour de France* is a world-famous bicycle race which lasts for three weeks. Its 2,100 miles (3,400 km) are broken into 20 stages which cover many of the different terrains that make up the French countryside. 2003 marks the 100th year of the *Tour*.



BRETONS

This Celtic people only assimilated into the French mainstream in the 19th century. This traditional woman's hat is called a *coiffe*.



The Eiffel Tower.



CAFÉ CULTURE

The Champs Elysées is the most famous street in Paris. Wide, tree-lined sidewalks mean people can sit outdoors at its cafés and restaurants and watch the world go by. Dining, or just drinking a coffee at an outdoor cafe, is an everyday pleasure greatly valued by the French people.